



Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay | Mission Aviation Academy

Aviation & Aerospace Complete Career Pathway Guide

CAREER GUIDE

Where to Start • What to Explore • How to Get There

16 Sections | 7 Career Families | Tampa North Aero Park (X39), Wesley Chapel, FL | Version 6 • Fall 2026 Edition

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Aviation is bigger than the cockpit. Explore every career the sky has to offer.



About This Guide & Our Partnerships

Our Legal Structure

Mission Aviation Academy (MAA) is the academic division of Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay, Inc. (iACT), a Florida 501(c)(3) nonprofit flying club. MAA operates as a DBA (doing business as) of iACT for official filing and tax purposes.

Flight Training Partners

Flight instruction is delivered by Central Florida Flight Training (Erik Meredith, Owner/Chief CFI — CFI/CFII/MEI/AGI/IGI, Gold Seal — Zephyrhills, FL) and Wings of an Angel Aviation (Josh Torres, CFI — Tampa, FL).

Maintenance (LSRM) Training Partner

Aircraft maintenance training is delivered through Hangar 777, LLC (Jurupa Valley, CA), an FAA-accepted Light Sport Repairman Maintenance provider.

Academic & Military-Youth Partnerships

MAA is a K-12 feeder partner and a pre-collegiate CROP volunteer with Pasco-Hernando State College (PHSC) and works with JROTC/ROTC units across Tampa Bay and Florida.

Not a Flight School

iACT/MAA is not a certificated flight school and does not itself hold an FAA Part 61 or Part 141 school certificate.

Our Flight & Ground Instructors

MAA-affiliated CFIs Matthews, Mednick, and Floyd conduct certificate flight instruction through our partner schools' aircraft. MAA's own Cessna 172 is for discovery flights and flying club rental only.

Scholarship Provider

MAA is an approved Florida Step Up For Students (SUFS) scholarship provider.

★ **PLEASE NOTE:** Program partners, schedules, and availability are subject to change. Contact MAA directly to confirm current details before enrolling or relying on any specific date in this guide.

What's Inside — Sixteen Sections

Seven career families, four action steps, a salary block, a planning block, and three new additions: Corporate Pilot & Independent CFI, the sport pilot and glider ladder, and the Wealth Ladder from Your Aviation Blueprint.

SECTION	WHAT IT COVERS	PRIORITY
1 — The 7 Career Families	Every lane in aviation and aerospace, and which require flying	START HERE
2 — Flight Operations	FAA certificate ladder, Student Pilot through ATP, and where to train	HIGH
3 — Corporate Pilot & Independent CFI	Business aviation, freelance instructing, and how they compare to airline and military pilot tracks	NEW
4 — Aviation Maintenance	A&P, IA, and avionics credentials; national mechanic shortage	NO DEGREE
5 — UAS / Drone Operations	Part 107, waivers, and seven industries hiring now	FASTEST ENTRY
6 — Air Traffic & Safety	ATC, FAA safety inspection, flight service, airport operations	AGE-CAPPED
7 — Aerospace & Defense	Engineering, intelligence, cyber, program management, manufacturing	HIGH
8 — Management & Education	Dispatch, airport leadership, logistics, curriculum, insurance	MEDIUM
9 — Where to Go Next	Explore, Connect, Train, Apply — named resources and funding	ACTION
10 — Salary Snapshot	Industry ranges plus BLS-verified national medians	REFERENCE
11-14 — Plan Your Path	Cost, timeline, eligibility gates, the 80% problem, first 12 months	PLANNING
15 — Sport Pilot & Glider	Age gates, MOSAIC, the stacked route, and what each rung pays	NEW
16 — The Wealth Ladder	Age 14 to 30, from Your Aviation Blueprint v11.21	NEW

The Numbers Behind the Opportunity

PILOTS NEEDED

674,000

New pilots required worldwide over the next 20 years (Boeing Pilot & Technician Outlook 2026–2045).

TECHNICIANS NEEDED

728,000

New maintenance technicians required worldwide over the same period.

CABIN CREW NEEDED

1,023,000

New cabin crew members — over 2.4 million aviation professionals in total.

REMOTE PILOTS

493,396

FAA remote pilot certificates issued through December 2025; projected 628,600 by 2030.

PRESSURE POINT	WHAT THE DATA SHOWS	SOURCE
Mechanic shortage	10% shortage of certificated mechanics in 2025; still 7% — about 10,000 mechanics — in 2035	ATEC / Oliver Wyman 2025 Pipeline Report
Empty training seats	Roughly one-third of A&P school seats sit unfilled — awareness, not capacity, is the constraint	ATEC 2025 Pipeline Report
Controller pipeline	FAA actively hiring; average certified earnings exceed \$155,000 within 3 years of Academy graduation	FAA ATC hiring (faa.gov/atc-hiring)
Retirement-driven demand	About two-thirds of the 20-year personnel demand comes from attrition and retirements	Boeing PTO

★ **THE BOTTOM LINE:** The shortage is not a talking point. It is a documented, decade-long gap between the number of people the industry needs and the number entering the pipeline.

SECTION 1

The 7 Career Families of Aviation & Aerospace

Aviation and aerospace careers fall into seven broad families. You do not have to be a pilot to have a career in the sky.

Only 2 of the 7 families require flying at all.

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The 7 Career Families

CAREER FAMILY	EXAMPLE ROLES	REQUIRES FLYING?
Flight Operations	Pilot, CFI, Check Airman, Air Carrier Ops	Yes
Aviation Maintenance	A&P Mechanic, Avionics Tech, Inspector, IA	No
Air Traffic & Safety	ATC Controller, Safety Inspector, FSS Specialist	No
UAS / Drone Operations	Drone Pilot, UAS Operator, Mapping Tech	Part 107 only
Aerospace & Defense	Aerospace Engineer, Systems Analyst, Test Tech	No
Aviation Management	Airport Director, Dispatcher, Logistics Manager	No
Education & Training	CFI, Sim Instructor, Curriculum Developer	Sometimes

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Pick the family first — the credential comes second. Five of the seven families never require you to touch the controls.

SECTION 2

Flight Operations: The Pilot Pathway

The FAA certificate ladder is sequential and public. Every rung has published hour minimums, a written exam, and a checkride.

ATP minimums drop to 1,000 hrs with a degree — 750 hrs with military time.

FAA Certificate Roadmap

CERTIFICATE / RATING	MINIMUM REQUIREMENTS & NOTES
Student Pilot Certificate	Age 16 (14 for glider/balloon); FAA medical; no written exam required
Private Pilot License (PPL)	40 hrs total (20 dual, 10 solo minimum); written exam + checkride
Instrument Rating (IR)	50 hrs cross-country PIC; 40 hrs instrument time; written + checkride
Commercial Pilot (CPL)	250 hrs total time; written + checkride; you can now be paid to fly
Certified Flight Instructor (CFI)	CPL + instrument rating; written + checkride; teach and build hours
Airline Transport Pilot (ATP)	1,500 hrs (1,000 w/ college degree; 750 w/ military); First Class medical
★ CAREER ALERT: Each rung is a job, not just a step. CFI is the rung that pays you to accumulate the hours the ATP requires.	

Where to Train — Five Routes to the Left Seat



Part 61 Flight Schools

Flexible scheduling, pay-as-you-go. Most local FBOs — including the field at X39.



Part 141 Flight Schools

Structured curriculum on an FAA-approved syllabus; fewer total hours required.



University Aviation Programs

B.S. degree plus flight certificates combined — Embry-Riddle, FAMU, Purdue, and others.



Military Service

The most direct funded path. Air Force, Navy, Army, Coast Guard, and Marine Corps all train pilots.



Community College Bridge Programs

Affordable entry point before a university transfer; often Pell-eligible.

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Five routes, one certificate. Cost and schedule differ; the FAA practical test standard does not.

SECTION 3

Corporate Pilot & Independent CFI

Two pilot-career tracks most guides skip — flying for a company instead of an airline, and building a freelance instructing business instead of working for a flight school.

Corporate captains now average \$188,800+ — closing the gap with major-airline pay.

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Corporate & Charter Pilot: Flying for a Company, Not an Airline

ROLE	DETAILS
Corporate / Charter First Officer (Entry point)	Smaller business aircraft (light jets, turboprops); typically Commercial + Instrument rating, 500–1,500 total hours
Corporate Captain — Mid-Size Cabin	Type-rated PIC on aircraft like the Citation or Learjet family; ATP typically required
Corporate Captain — Large-Cabin / Long-Range	Gulfstream, Global, and Falcon-class jets; the highest-paying corporate cockpit seat
Chief Pilot / Aviation Dept. Manager	Oversees flight department operations, scheduling, and safety compliance — a non-flying leadership track
Path In	ATP certificate plus type rating(s); most operators hire pilots with Part 135 charter or airline-adjacent flight time
★ CAREER ALERT: 2026 average pay across all business-aviation positions: \$202,499 (BizJetJobs survey, 2,847 pilots). Large-cabin captains: \$220K–\$350K+.	

The Independent CFI: Building a Freelance Instructing Business

STRUCTURE	DETAILS
W-2 Flight School CFI (Employed)	Typical 2026 pay: \$35K-\$60K base plus \$8K-\$15K benefits (\$43K-\$75K total); scheduled students, supplied aircraft
1099 Independent CFI	Bills students directly; supplies own insurance, aircraft access, and marketing — a P&L decision, not a lifestyle choice
Independent Hourly Rates	\$45-\$65/hr new instructors in average markets; established independents \$50-\$125/hr, up to \$150-\$300/hr for type-specific training
Realistic Income	50-70 flight hrs/month once established; \$35K-\$95K+ annually depending on hours and rate
Insurance & Liability	Avemco non-owned CFI liability policies run \$160-\$510/yr; professional liability needs a separate policy
★ CAREER ALERT: Self-employment tax takes an effective ~14% off the top of 1099 income — the single biggest math mistake new independents make.	

Corporate vs. Airline vs. Military vs. CFI/Flight School Owner

TRACK	ENTRY PAY • TOP PAY • PATH IN
Corporate / Charter Pilot (Business aviation)	Entry \$90K–\$120K • Top (large-cabin captain) \$220K–\$350K+ • Path: ATP + type rating, built through Part 91, Part 135 charter time
Major Airline Pilot	Entry \$80K–\$100K (regional) • Top (senior captain) \$250K–\$350K+ • Path: ATP (1,500 hrs), seniority-driven ladder
Military Pilot	Entry: flight pay + BAH + benefits • Top: senior officer command pay + pension • Path: commissioning source, service flight school, no personal training cost
CFI / Flight School Owner	Entry \$35K–\$60K (W-2) or \$45–\$65/hr (1099) • Top \$95K+ owning a school • Path: CFI certificate, build a student base or start/buy a school
Which Fits You	Corporate = steady schedule, strong ceiling • Airline = highest ceiling, seniority grind • Military = zero personal training cost • CFI = fastest income, caps sooner
★ CAREER ALERT: This is the comparison most guides skip. All four are legitimate careers — pick based on lifestyle and training-cost tolerance, not headline pay alone.	

Business Aviation Careers: Beyond the Cockpit

ROLE	SALARY & PATH IN
Aircraft Sales Broker (High-earning, non-pilot)	Represents buyers or sellers of corporate/private aircraft. No FAA license required. Commission: 2–5% per deal. Aircraft range: \$300K–\$75M+. Top brokers earn \$200K–\$1M+/yr.
FBO / Ground Operations Manager	Oversees fuel, hangar, ramp, and customer ops at a Fixed-Base Operator. Salary: \$65K–\$110K. Path: aviation management degree or ops experience.
Charter Sales & Operations Coordinator	Sells and schedules Part 135 charter flights. Ops: \$45K–\$75K. Senior charter sales: \$80K–\$120K+. Path: aviation background + sales skills.
Business Aviation Director / VP of Aviation	Leads a corporate flight department — pilots, aircraft, compliance, and budget. Salary: \$150K–\$350K+. Path: Chief Pilot → Dept. Manager → Director.
Path In (Aircraft Broker)	No license required. Network into the industry via NBAA, aviation law firms, or aircraft management companies. NBAA Certified Aviation Manager (CAM) credential strengthens credibility.
★ BUSINESS AVIATION FACT: Business aviation employs 1.2M people in the U.S. and generates \$250B+ in economic output annually (NBAA). The aircraft broker field has no formal licensing barrier — hustle, network, and market knowledge are the entry requirements.	

SECTION 4

Aviation Maintenance: A&P & Avionics

Maintenance professionals keep aircraft airworthy. No flying required, no four-year degree required, and the shortage is documented.

728,000 new maintenance technicians needed worldwide over 20 years.

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Maintenance Credentials & How to Earn Them

CREDENTIAL	PATH TO GET THERE
A&P Certificate (Airframe & Powerplant)	FAA Part 147 school (18–24 months) OR 30 months documented hands-on experience, then written / oral / practical tests
Inspection Authorization (IA)	3 years as an A&P + annual exercise + FAA approval; allows independent aircraft inspections
Avionics Technician	A&P or FCC license; focus on avionics and aircraft electronics systems
FAA Light Sport Repairman	100 hours on a specific aircraft type; covers light sport maintenance
Military MOS → Civilian Credit	Military aircraft mechanic experience counts toward A&P eligibility
★ CAREER ALERT: BLS puts the aircraft mechanic median at \$78,680 and avionics technicians at \$81,390 (May 2024) — with no four-year degree required.	

Where to Train — Maintenance



FAA Part 147 Aviation Maintenance Technician Schools

The full directory of approved schools is published at [faa.gov](https://www.faa.gov).



Named Programs

Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, Northland Pioneer College, Lake Area Tech, and others.



Community & Technical Colleges

A&P programs at local colleges — the lowest-cost civilian route.



Military Service

Air Force 2A series, Navy AD / AE / AME ratings, Army 15-series MOS.

★ **VETERAN NOTE:** Document every maintenance hour you logged in uniform — it converts directly into A&P test eligibility. Roughly one-third of A&P school seats nationwide sit unfilled.

SECTION 5

UAS / Drone Operations: The Fastest Entry Point

Part 107 certification is the lowest barrier to a legitimate aviation career — no flight test, no medical, minimum age 16.

493,396 FAA remote pilot certificates issued through December 2025.

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Part 107 Credentials & Roles

CREDENTIAL / ROLE	DETAILS
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot Certificate	Minimum age 16; pass the Aeronautical Knowledge Test; no flight test required; valid 24 months
Advanced Operations Waiver	Apply to the FAA for BVLOS, night operations, and operations over people
Industry Certifications	DJI certified, Autel, senseFly — manufacturer-specific training
UAS Operator / Mission Specialist	Real estate, agriculture, public safety, film, infrastructure inspection
Drone Data Analyst	GIS, photogrammetry, mapping, and thermal imaging analysis
★ CAREER ALERT: Certificate in weeks, not years. MAA teaches this course directly at X39 — then you stack an industry specialty on top of it.	

Industries Hiring Drone Operators Now

Public Safety Law enforcement, fire service, search and rescue.
Typical roles: UAS unit operator, tactical flight officer

Construction & Infrastructure Site surveys, bridge and pipeline inspection.
Typical roles: Survey pilot, documentation technician

Logistics & Delivery Amazon, UPS Flight Forward, Wing.
Typical roles: Delivery UAS operator, fleet technician

Environmental Monitoring Wildlife surveys, climate research, conservation.
Typical roles: Survey pilot, thermal imaging analyst

Agriculture Precision farming, crop health monitoring, yield mapping.
Typical roles: Spray operator, crop-scouting pilot

Real Estate & Media Photography, videography, listing and campaign marketing.
Typical roles: Listing pilot, aerial cinematographer

Military & Defense ISR and reconnaissance work under DoD contracts.
Typical roles: Sensor operator, contractor UAS technician

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Construction, energy and agriculture are the largest commercial drone verticals. The specialty you choose sets the pay ceiling.

SECTION 6

Air Traffic Control & Aviation Safety

Federal aviation careers with published pay scales, structured hiring pipelines, and no flying requirement.

FAA hiring requires you to be under 31 — plan early.

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Air Traffic & Safety Careers

CAREER	PATH & NOTES
Air Traffic Controller (FAA)	AT-CTI college program OR military ATC experience; must be under 31 at application; FAA reports average certified earnings above \$155,000 within 3 years of Academy graduation
FAA Aviation Safety Inspector	A&P or pilot certificate plus experience; federal GS-12 to GS-15 pay scale
Flight Service Specialist	Weather briefings, NOTAMs, ATC support; contractors such as Leidos hire regularly
Safety Management Systems (SMS)	Airlines and airports hire SMS specialists; degree plus aviation experience preferred
Airport Operations	ARFF, ramp control, operations coordinator; city / county government jobs and TSA
★ TIME-CRITICAL: The FAA requires applicants to be under 31 years of age at application. Certain preference-eligible veterans with qualifying ATC experience may be considered beyond that age — verify against the specific USAJOBS announcement. Hiring cycles run 6–18 months.	

Where to Start for ATC



FAA AT-CTI Schools

Approved college programs that feed directly into FAA hiring announcements.



Military ATC

Air Force 1C1X1, Army 15Q, Navy AC — the most direct path into the FAA pipeline.



FAA Academy — Oklahoma City, OK

Required training for selected candidates, followed by 1–3 years of on-the-job training.



usajobs.gov

Search series 2152 (Air Traffic Control) and 1825 (Aviation Safety).

★ **ACTION ITEM:** Set a usajobs.gov alert today. FAA ATC bids open and close in days, and candidates must pass the Air Traffic Skills Assessment (ATSA).

SECTION 7

Aerospace Engineering & Defense

The aerospace and defense sector employs 2.5 million Americans and exports more than any other U.S. manufacturing sector.

You do not need to be an engineer to work here.

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Roles, Degrees & Employers

ROLE	DEGREE / CREDENTIAL NEEDED	EMPLOYERS
Aerospace Engineer	B.S. Aerospace or Mechanical Engineering	NASA, Boeing, Lockheed, SpaceX
Systems Analyst	B.S. Systems or Engineering	Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, SAIC
Cybersecurity / Space	B.S. Computer Science + Security+ or CEH	Space Force, NSA, L3Harris
Intelligence Analyst	B.S. any field + TS/SCI clearance	DIA, NGA, SOCOM, defense contractors
Program Manager	PMP + aviation or defense experience	All major primes and DoD agencies
Manufacturing Technician	2-year degree or vocational certificate	Boeing, Spirit AeroSystems, GE Aviation

★ **CAREER ALERT:** A security clearance is a credential. BLS puts aerospace engineers at a \$134,830 median and aerospace engineering technicians at \$79,830 (May 2024).

Top Employers — Aerospace & Defense

LEGACY DEFENSE PRIMES
Boeing · Lockheed Martin · Northrop Grumman · Raytheon · General Dynamics
SPACE & NEW ENTRANTS
NASA · SpaceX · Blue Origin · Sierra Nevada Corporation
TECHNOLOGY & SERVICES
L3Harris · SAIC · Leidos · Booz Allen Hamilton · CACI
FEDERAL & MILITARY
U.S. Space Force · U.S. Air Force · SOCOM · DIA · NGA

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Every organization on this slide hires technicians, analysts, and program managers — not only engineers.

SECTION 8

Aviation Education, Management & Logistics

The business side of aviation: dispatch, airport leadership, supply chain, training, and insurance.

Aircraft Dispatcher — a licensed airline career built on roughly 200 hours of study.

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Management, Education & Logistics Careers

CAREER	HOW TO GET THERE
Aircraft Dispatcher	FAA Aircraft Dispatcher License; approximately 200 hours of study; airlines and cargo operators
Airport Director / Manager	Aviation management degree plus experience; city, county, and airport authority jobs
Aviation Logistics	Supply chain degree or certificate plus aviation knowledge; airline operations and MRO supply
Flight School Owner / CFI	CFI and CFII ratings plus a business plan; earn revenue while building flight hours
Aviation Curriculum Developer	Teaching certificate plus aviation credentials; growing with STEM programs nationwide
Aviation Insurance Underwriter	Finance or business degree plus FAA knowledge; a niche field, and well paid
★ CAREER ALERT: Dispatchers share operational control of the flight with the captain. BLS tracks them under airfield operations specialists — a different category from air traffic controllers.	

SECTION 9

Where to Go & What to Do Next

Four steps, in order: Explore the free resources, Connect with people in the room, Train on someone else's money, Apply through the right portal.

Explore → Connect → Train → Apply

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Step 1 — Explore (Free Resources)

RESOURCE	WHAT YOU FIND THERE
FAA Career Resources — faa.gov/jobs	Every FAA career path, hiring portals, and the AT-CTI schools list
Aviation Week Network — aviationweek.com	Industry news, career intelligence, and workforce data
AOPA — aopa.org	Pilot resources, flight training finder, and a scholarship database
EAA — eaa.org	Youth aviation programs, the Ray Scholarship, and local chapters
AOPA Scholarship Portal	\$1,000–\$10,000 scholarships for student pilots and additional ratings
Tuskegee Airmen Inc. — tuskegeeairmen.org	Scholarships, mentorship, and legacy chapters nationwide
Women in Aviation Int'l — wai.org	Annual scholarships, mentors, and a careers database
OBAP — obap.org	Mentorship, scholarships, networking, and a career pipeline
Airlines for America — airlines.org	Industry data, workforce reports, and career pathways
USAJOBS — usajobs.gov	All federal aviation jobs: FAA, DoD, NASA, TSA, Space Force

Step 2 — Connect (Get in a Room)



Local EAA Chapter — eaa.org/chapters

Young Eagles flights are FREE for ages 8–17.



Attend an Air Show

Talk to every exhibitor in the career tent. Collect names, not just brochures.



Join OBAP

Organization of Black Aerospace Professionals — mentorship plus scholarships.



Join Women in Aviation International (WAI)

Open to ALL genders; one of the largest scholarship programs in the industry.



Find your nearest Civil Air Patrol (CAP) squadron

Free aerospace education, leadership training, and scholarships.



Attend I/ITSEC or Aviation Week Conferences

Defense, simulation, and aerospace exposure with hiring managers present.

★ **CAREER ALERT:** AOPA's research found students quit over lost momentum and poor communication far more often than raw cost. Mentors solve both.

Step 3 — Train (Funded Pathways)

FUNDING SOURCE	WHAT IT COVERS
GI Bill / Chapter 33	Full tuition plus housing for veterans at Part 141 schools and universities
VR&E (Vocational Rehabilitation & Employment)	Covers 100% of training for service-connected disabled veterans
Florida SUFS Scholarship	Aviation STEM, tutoring, and drone courses for eligible K-12 families
WIOA (Workforce Innovation & Opportunity Act)	CareerSource-funded training for eligible adults in career transition
AOPA Foundation Scholarship	Student pilot training scholarships — apply at aopa.org/scholarships
EAA Ray Aviation Scholarship	Up to \$10,000 for student pilots — eaa.org/rayscholarship
Airlines for America Pathways	United Aviate, American Cadet, Delta Propel — sponsored ATP pipelines
Pell Grant + FAFSA	Community college aviation programs are Pell-eligible
NATA Scholarship	Industry association scholarships — nata.aero/scholarships

★ **MAA GUIDANCE:** MAA families start with SUFS and WIOA. Veterans start with VR&E. Nobody pays retail before checking all nine.

Step 4 — Apply (Hiring Portals)

FEDERAL	usajobs.gov FAA, NASA, TSA, DoD, and Space Force — all GS-series federal jobs.	GENERAL	Indeed / LinkedIn Search 'aviation' plus your city or your specialty.
AIRLINES	Airline Career Portals United, Delta, American, Southwest, FedEx, UPS.	DEFENSE	Defense Contractors Lockheed Martin, Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, and Boeing careers pages.
INDUSTRY	AeroCareers.com Aviation-specific job board.	INDUSTRY	avjobs.com Pilot, dispatch, maintenance, and operations listings.
EMERGING	UAS & eVTOL Startups DroneBase, Joby, Wisk, Archer — hiring aggressively.		

★ **SEQUENCE:** Federal hiring runs the slowest clock — FAA cycles run 6 to 18 months. File usajobs.gov first, then work the commercial portals.

SECTION 10

Aviation Career Salary Snapshot

Industry ranges first, then BLS-verified national medians. Four of the seven tracks require no four-year degree.

BLS medians are the figures to use in grant and sponsor materials.

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Salary Snapshot — Entry vs. Experienced

CAREER	ENTRY SALARY	EXPERIENCED
Airline Pilot (ATP / Major)	\$80K-\$100K (Regional)	\$250K-\$350K+
Corporate / Charter Pilot	\$90K-\$120K	\$220K-\$350K+ (large-cabin captain)
A&P Mechanic	\$45K-\$55K	\$80K-\$120K+
Air Traffic Controller (FAA)	\$60K-\$70K	\$140K-\$180K+
Aerospace Engineer	\$75K-\$90K	\$130K-\$200K+
UAS / Drone Operator	\$40K-\$55K	\$75K-\$150K (specialist)
Aircraft Dispatcher	\$50K-\$65K	\$90K-\$130K
Avionics Technician	\$50K-\$65K	\$85K-\$120K
★ READ THE RIGHT COLUMN: These are industry ranges and vary by region, employer, and seniority. The next slide gives the federally verified medians for citation.		

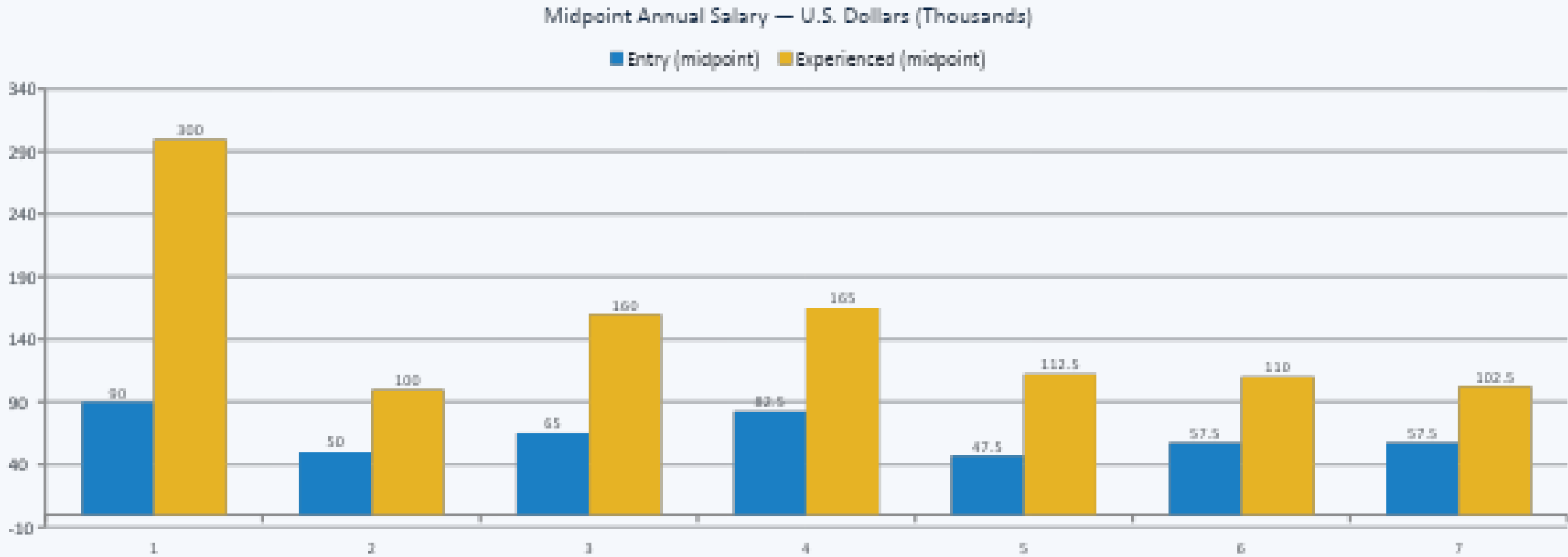
BLS-Verified National Medians (May 2024)

Use these figures — not industry ranges — in grant applications, ETPL submissions, and sponsor materials.

OCCUPATION (BLS CATEGORY)	MEDIAN ANNUAL WAGE	10-YEAR OUTLOOK (2024–34)
Airline Pilots, Copilots & Flight Engineers	\$226,600	+4% — about as fast as average
Commercial Pilots	\$122,670	Included in pilot category
Air Traffic Controllers	\$144,580	+1% — slower than average
Aerospace Engineers	\$134,830	+6% — faster than average
Avionics Technicians	\$81,390	+5% — faster than average
Aircraft Mechanics & Service Technicians	\$78,680	+5% — faster than average
Aerospace Engineering Technologists & Techs	\$79,830	+8% — much faster than average
Flight Attendants	\$67,130	Growth reported by BLS
All U.S. Occupations (benchmark)	\$49,500	—

★ **BENCHMARK:** The median U.S. worker earned \$49,500 in May 2024. Six of the eight aviation occupations above pay more than 1.5 times that, and four require no four-year degree.

Earnings Range by Career Track



Midpoints of the published industry ranges on the previous slides. BLS national medians appear on the slide before this one.

SECTION 11-14

Plan Your Path: Cost, Eligibility & First Steps

What it costs, how long it takes, who qualifies, why most people quit — and exactly what to do in your first twelve months.

This is the section most career guides leave out.

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What It Costs and How Long It Takes

CREDENTIAL	TYPICAL COST (2026)	TYPICAL TIME	NOTES
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot	\$175 test + prep	2–6 weeks	Lowest-cost legitimate aviation credential
Private Pilot License (PPL)	\$15,000–\$20,000	3–12 months	FAA minimum is 40 hrs; most students need 60–75
Instrument Rating	\$10,000–\$15,000	3–6 months	Required for the professional track
Commercial Pilot (CPL)	Part of full program	6–12 months	250 hrs total time; first paid-to-fly rung
Zero to Airline-Ready	\$60,000–\$120,000	18 months–3 years	PPL+IR+CPL+ME+CFI; Part 61 lower, structured higher
A&P Certificate	Varies by school	18–24 months	Or 30 months documented experience, then testing
ATC (FAA Academy path)	No tuition — FAA pays	6–18 mo + 1–3 yr OJT	Paid during Academy; must be under 31

★ **COST DISCIPLINE:** The biggest cost variable is not the hourly rate — it is how long you take. Training 3–5 times per week costs far less in total than training once a week.

Who Qualifies — Check This Before You Spend

FAA MEDICAL CERTIFICATES		
CLASS	REQUIRED FOR	TYPICAL VALIDITY
First Class	Airline Transport Pilot (ATP) — airline captains and first officers	6–12 months depending on age
Second Class	Commercial Pilot — any paid flying	12 months
Third Class	Private Pilot, Student Pilot, Recreational	24–60 months depending on age
BasicMed	Private pilot privileges in qualifying aircraft, in lieu of Third Class	Per BasicMed rule requirements
No FAA medical	Part 107 remote pilot; glider and balloon operations	Not applicable

AGE, CITIZENSHIP & BACKGROUND GATES	
GATE	REQUIREMENT
Age minimums	14 — solo glider/balloon 16 — solo airplane and Part 107 17 — Private Pilot 18 — Commercial 23 — ATP (21 restricted)
Air traffic control	U.S. citizen; under 31 at application (limited veteran exceptions — verify per announcement); ATSA test; medical and background checks
Defense & intelligence	U.S. citizenship and a security clearance (Secret to TS/SCI); background investigation required

★ **DO THIS FIRST:** See an Aviation Medical Examiner before spending a dollar on flight training. The FAA issues thousands of Special Issuance medicals each year — do not assume you are disqualified.

Military Experience → Civilian Aviation Credential

MILITARY BACKGROUND	CIVILIAN CREDENTIAL IT FEEDS	HOW IT SHORTENS THE PATH
Aircraft maintenance (AF 2A, Navy AD/AE/AME, Army 15-series)	FAA A&P Certificate	Documented experience counts toward A&P testing eligibility
Military ATC (AF 1C1X1, Army 15Q, Navy AC)	FAA Air Traffic Controller	Direct hiring pathway; qualifying experience may support a veteran age exception
Military pilot	Commercial / ATP	ATP minimum drops from 1,500 hrs to 750 hrs
Intelligence, cyber, ISR	Intelligence Analyst, Cyber / Space roles	Existing clearance is often the hardest credential to obtain
Any honorable service	Any FAA credential	GI Bill Chapter 33 and VR&E fund training; VR&E covers 100% for service-connected disabled veterans

★ **VETERAN PRIORITY:** MAA is led by a retired Naval officer and 100% disabled veteran. Bring your DD-214 and training records to the first conversation — they are worth money and months.

Why Most People Quit — and How You Won't

THE ATTRITION RATE

~80%

of student pilots quit before earning a certificate (AOPA flight training research; reaffirmed at NAFI Summit 2025).

THE REAL CAUSE

Momentum

AOPA found the top drivers are lost momentum, poor communication, and being misled on time and money — not cost or aptitude.

THE MAA ANSWER

Structure

Published syllabus, assigned mentor, milestone tracking, and transparent cost expectations from day one.

THE FOUR DANGER WINDOWS — KNOW THEM BEFORE YOU HIT THEM		
WINDOW	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW TO SURVIVE IT
First 15 hours	Progress feels slow and landings feel impossible	Fly 2–3 times per week; expect the plateau
Pre-solo (20–30 hrs)	Performance anxiety, instructor changes, weather delays	Keep the same CFI; use a sim for procedures
Post-solo (30–60 hrs)	Knowledge test anxiety and budget fatigue	Pass the written early; lock in funding before you start
Pre-checkride	Fear of failure this close to the finish	Mock orals and a scheduled DPE date

★ **THE WHOLE POINT:** The map is what the other 80% never had. Knowing where the cliffs are is most of what it takes to get past them.

The Twelve-Month Action Plan

DAYS 1-30	DAYS 31-90	MONTHS 4-6	MONTHS 7-12
Decide & Qualify • Pick ONE career family from Section 1 • Book an AME appointment and get your medical • Take a discovery flight or a drone session • Create your usajobs.gov profile	Fund & Enroll • Apply to every scholarship you qualify for • File FAFSA; check SUFS, WIOA, GI Bill, VR&E • Enroll in Part 107 or ground school • Join EAA, OBAP, WAI, or CAP	Train & Test • Pass the FAA Knowledge Test for your track • Fly or study 2-3 times per week — protect momentum • Find a mentor and check in monthly • Log everything from day one	Certify & Apply • Earn the first credential — Part 107, PPL, or A&P testing • Build a résumé around the credential • Apply through the portals in Section 9 • Set the next rung and repeat the cycle

★ **ONE YEAR FROM TODAY:** A credential in hand, a mentor on speed dial, and a funded plan for the next rung. That is a realistic twelve months — if you start this week.

SECTION 15

Sport Pilot, Glider & the Stacked Ladder

There is a lower, earlier, cheaper set of rungs than the Private Pilot certificate — and stacking them in the right order is the whole strategy.

A student may legally solo a glider at 14.

The Real Age Gates

CERTIFICATE	MIN AGE	MINIMUM FLIGHT TIME	NOTE
Solo — glider or balloon	14	Instructor endorsement	The earliest a person may legally fly an aircraft alone in the U.S.
Private Pilot — Glider	16	10 hours, 20 flights	The fewest hours to any full FAA pilot certificate
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot	16	No flight time	Knowledge test only — the first rung that pays
Sport Pilot	17	20 hours	Driver's license may substitute for an FAA medical
Private Pilot — Airplane	17	40 hours	Most students need 60–75 hours in practice
Commercial Pilot — Glider	18	25 hours	First certificate that allows you to be paid to fly
CFI — Glider	18	No hours beyond Commercial	Instruction hours count toward the 1,500-hour ATP
Commercial Pilot — Airplane	18	250 hours	The airplane ladder's paid rung
Airline Transport Pilot	23	1,500 hours	Restricted ATP at 21 under 14 CFR 61.160

★ **READ THE FIRST ROW AGAIN:** A student may legally solo a glider at fourteen — three years before a classmate can solo an airplane, and at roughly one-fifth the cost.

Sport Pilot After MOSAIC

The FAA's MOSAIC rule reshaped the sport pilot certificate in two phases: privileges expanded October 22, 2025, and light-sport aircraft certification changed July 24, 2026. Roughly three-quarters of the existing GA fleet is now reachable on sport pilot privileges.

WHAT CHANGED	DETAIL
Aircraft you may fly	Defined by performance, not weight. Clean stall speed at or below 59 knots CAS, up to four seats (14 CFR 61.316)
Passengers	Still one passenger maximum, even in a four-seat aircraft
Night flight	Now permitted with an endorsement plus BasicMed or a third-class medical
Retractable gear / constant-speed prop	Now permitted with the appropriate endorsements
Medical	Unchanged — a valid U.S. driver's license may substitute for an FAA medical certificate
Getting paid as pilot in command	Still prohibited. A sport pilot may not carry passengers or property for compensation, nor fly in furtherance of a business
Aerial work	Since July 24, 2026, qualifying light-sport aircraft may perform paid aerial photography, survey, pipeline and powerline patrol, and banner towing under 14 CFR 91.327
★ THE INCOME RULE: Sport Pilot is a cost rung, not an income rung — you cannot be paid to fly people or cargo. The CFI-Sport Pilot certificate above it is the rung that pays, and MOSAIC made that explicit in 2025.	

The Stacked Ladder — How the Rungs Connect

Three ladders, one career. Each costs more to reach the instructor level than the one before it — which is exactly why the motorglider comes first.

RUNG	AIRCRAFT	CERTIFICATES & AGES	ALL-IN COST
Rung 1 — Glider	Motorglider	Solo at 14 · Private Glider at 16 (10 hrs) · Commercial Glider at 18 (25 hrs) · CFI-Glider adds no hours	\$6,880–\$8,050
Rung 2 — Light Sport	LSA trainer	Sport Pilot at 17 (20 hrs) · CFI-S requires 150 hrs total time (14 CFR 61.411)	\$22,475–\$26,425
WHAT EACH RUNG PAYS — [BLS] FEDERALLY VERIFIED · [MKT] MARKET-OBSERVED · [REG] SET BY REGULATION			
ROLE		INCOME	CLASS
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot (age 16)		First paid work on the ladder — offsets glider training cost	[MKT]
Sport Pilot		\$0 as pilot in command — limited aerial work only	[REG]
CFI-Glider (club or commercial)		\$20–\$30/hr	[MKT]
CFI-Glider (independent)		\$40–\$60/hr	[MKT]
Commercial Pilot–Glider		\$25–\$40 per ride flight; \$150–\$400 per operating day; \$16K–\$40K/yr by season	[MKT]
Glider Tow Pilot		\$45,606/yr average; many clubs pay in free flight time instead	[MKT]
CFI-Sport Pilot		\$25–\$40/hr entry; \$35,000–\$55,000/yr	[MKT]
★ WHY THIS MATTERS: CFI-Glider hours count toward the 1,500 hours the ATP requires (14 CFR 61.159). Glider instruction is ATP-qualifying flight time bought at a fraction of airplane rates.			

SECTION 16

The Aviation Wealth Ladder

Age 14 to age 30. Every rung, every certificate, and what each one pays — from Your Aviation Blueprint, Chapter 1.

One career. One percent at a time.

MAA



Where This Career Actually Lands You

TOP 10%	TOP 5%	TOP 1%	TOP 0.1%
\$169,000+ U.S. household income threshold.	\$339,000+ A senior regional captain reaches this band.	\$889,000+ Household threshold for the top one percent.	\$3M+ The upper bound of the income distribution.

The Argument

A major airline captain earning \$250,000 to \$500,000 sits inside the top 1 to 5% of American earners. Aviation is not a path to the median — it is a direct path to the top, and the first rung starts at fourteen with a glider.

★ **SOURCE:** Income percentile thresholds as cited in Your Aviation Blueprint, Chapter 1. Pathway data corrected to v11.21 (the Vollmer Pathway).

The Ladder — Age 14 to Age 30

AGE	RUNG	CERTIFICATE / REGULATION	WHAT IT PAYS
14	Motorglider solo	Student certificate, CFI-G endorsement	\$0 — cost phase
16	Private Pilot–Glider + Part 107	10 hrs minimum — fewest hours to any full FAA certificate	Drone income begins
17	Sport Pilot	20 hrs, 14 CFR 61.315	\$0 as PIC
17	Private Pilot–Airplane + Instrument	40 hrs minimum — FAA minimum age	\$0 — cost phase
18	Commercial Glider + CFI-Glider	25 hrs total; CFI-G adds no hours beyond that	First paid flying
18	Commercial Airplane + CFI-Airplane	250 hrs total time	Instructor income
18–21	CFI-G + CFI-S + drone business	Stacked instruction and Part 107 commercial work	\$60K–\$80K/yr
21	Restricted ATP	14 CFR 61.160 — first officer only	Regional FO
23	Unrestricted ATP	14 CFR 61.159 — 1,500 hrs	Full ATP privileges
28–30	Regional Captain / Major First Officer	Seniority-driven	Six figures
30	Senior Captain / Captain	Seniority-driven	Seven figures

★ **THE COMPOUNDING RULE:** Every rung above 16 pays for the rung above it. The student who solos a motorglider at 14 does not borrow their way to an ATP — they earn their way there.

The Vollmer Pathway — Three Rungs, One Ladder

A glider has no engine. A motorglider has one: it takes off under its own power, and a student can fly it powered or shut the engine down and soar it, in the same flight. One aircraft delivers both glider time and genuine powered airplane time.

RAND'S OWN NUMBERS

- By age 16**
Roughly \$5,000 all-in on the glider ladder — offset to functionally zero by summer Part 107 drone earnings between 16 and 18.
- Age 18 to 21**
A paid flight instructor running a drone business earning \$60,000 to \$80,000 a year — funding the LSA and Airplane ladders out of income, not debt.
- Equipment note**
A TAA-equipped LSA delivers real credit toward Rung 3 that a non-TAA aircraft cannot (14 CFR 61.129(j)).

THE REGULATIONS THAT CONTROL THE MONEY

REGULATION	WHY IT MATTERS TO INCOME
14 CFR 61.413(d)	MOSAIC expressly authorized paying a CFI-Sport Pilot. Effective October 22, 2025 — the newest income door on the ladder
14 CFR 61.159	CFI-Glider hours count toward the 1,500-hour ATP requirement — ATP-qualifying time at a fraction of airplane rates
14 CFR 61.160	Restricted ATP at 21 instead of 23 — two years of airline earnings recovered

Attribution: The Vollmer Pathway is the work of Rand Vollmer, Colonel, U.S. Army (Ret.) — CFI-Glider, Light Sport Repairman, DARPA Soaring SME. Cost and operational data traces to a documented 2010 source cited in Embry-Riddle capstone research. A fifteen-year documented model.

What Mission Aviation Academy Delivers

FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot Course

Classroom and cohort-based training at X39 — the fastest route to a credential.

Certificate Flight Training

Delivered through partner flight schools Central Florida Flight Training and Wings of an Angel Aviation, taught by MAA-affiliated CFIs Walter Matthews, Phil Mednick, and Ahviyona Floyd.

Seasonal STEM Camps

Summer, fall, winter, and spring camps combining aviation, drones, and hands-on engineering for youth of all ages.

Entrepreneurship & STEM Career Blueprint

Business coaching, startup fundamentals, career mapping, and personalized aviation/STEM pathways — each student’s road to Flight Plan 2030.

FAA Private Pilot Ground School

Five delivery tracks: 4-week intensive, 8-week standard, summer camps, and micro-lessons.

Aerospace & Mechanical Engineering

Hands-on design, build, and test curriculum — aircraft systems, aerodynamics, and engineering fundamentals for youth cohorts.

Micro-Lessons: Drones, Sims & AI Coding

Short-format sessions building real skills in drone operation, flight simulation, and AI/coding fundamentals.

Schools & Organizations

Bring MAA to your community. Inquire about curriculum licensing, becoming a referral partner, or booking LCDR Foster as a keynote speaker at your next event.

★ **FLIGHT PLAN 2030:** 300,000+ youth impacted. 722+ FAA credentials issued. 1,380+ students flown. Target: one million youth reached by 2030.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Pick ONE career family.
Research ONE resource.
Make ONE phone call.

The aviation world is waiting for people who look like you.

ONE

Family

Section 1 lists all seven.

ONE

Resource

Section 9, Step 1 lists ten.

ONE

Call

813-445-8889 • (833) FLY-STEM

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- admissions@missionaviationacademy.org
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RICKY THE EXPLORER



Ricky the Explorer: Takes a
Magic Flight — /ricky

Data Sources and Currency

FIGURE USED IN THIS GUIDE	SOURCE	AS OF
Median wages for all aviation occupations	U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook	May 2024
674,000 pilots / 728,000 technicians / 1,023,000 cabin crew	Boeing Pilot & Technician Outlook 2026–2045	2026
Mechanic shortage 10% (2025) narrowing to 7% (2035)	ATEC / Oliver Wyman Pipeline Report	2025
493,396 remote pilot certificates; 628,600 projected by 2030	FAA Aerospace Forecast FY 2026–2046	Dec 2025
ATC under-31 rule; \$155,000+ certified earnings	Federal Aviation Administration, faa.gov/atc-hiring	2026
~80% student pilot dropout rate	AOPA flight training research; SAFE; NAFI Summit 2025	2025
MOSAIC provisions and effective dates	FAA MOSAIC final rule — phase I Oct 22, 2025; phase II July 24, 2026	2026
Glider, tow pilot, and CFI-S income figures [MKT]	ZipRecruiter; operator published rates; instructor reporting; PayScale	2026
Wealth Ladder ages, hours, and cost brackets	Vollmer Pathway — Your Aviation Blueprint v11.21	2026

★ **VERIFICATION STANDARD:** Cite [BLS] figures in grant, ETPL, and sponsor submissions. [MKT] figures are market-observed and should be presented as ranges, not verified medians.

LCDR Ricardo “Tattoo” Foster, USN (Ret.)

Founder & Chief Executive Officer · Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay, Inc. / Mission Aviation Academy

36 years of combined service: 28 years of military service in naval aviation intelligence, U.S. Navy (Retired), plus 8 years of civilian aviation and education experience.

100% disabled veteran; mentored directly by the Tuskegee Airmen.

Founder and CEO of a Florida 501(c)(3) delivering aviation, STEM, AI, and entrepreneurship pathways to underserved youth.

Program Lead and Ground Instructor, FAA Private Pilot and Part 107 Remote Pilot programs at Tampa North Aero Park (X39).

Architect of Flight Plan 2030 — one million youth reached and \$10 million raised by 2030.

300,000+

Youth impacted

722+

FAA credentials issued

1,380+

Students flown